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KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 7: *Measures to Relieve Tension*¹

In the first six chapters of *Neurosis and Human Growth*, we learned about the dream house that is created by our neurotic imagination and built on the foundation of our search for a phantom glory. As neurotics, we believe that achieving this false glory will fulfill our craving for survival, security, self-confidence, and fulfillment. The foundation of our dream house is, however, as unstable as sand, but we hope that the framework of our personal law—our shoulds, claims, and taboos—will be strong enough to overcome that little weakness. This personal law unconsciously shapes our values and drives our judgments, and we waste precious energy slaving to comply with these neurotic standards of glory. But since the world and even our own choices regularly fall short of those standards, we live in the constant dread of self-hate with its self-sabotage, self-condemnation, and self-torment.

We feel proud of our little house, even though its foundation is built on sand and its framework constructed out of the flimsy judgments of our compulsive shoulds and claims. Our pride is invested in who we imagine ourselves to be and what we imagine we can do, but that pride is as vulnerable as wallpaper glued over cardboard. How easily our pride is hurt! Our paper shreds with the slightest insult or misunderstanding, and we find ourselves constantly running around with a glue gun and paint pot trying to keep up appearances. We paste together our shredding self-image by blaming others and life's adversities, punishing others or ourselves, and escaping into addictive behaviors. More and more of our energy goes into maintaining appearances, not just to fool others but to deceive ourselves. The more vulnerable the house, the greater the need for the glue gun and paint. That creates a lot of tension. Deep down we know that our house is built on sand and that the slightest spark will engulf the whole thing in flames. We are chronically anxious.

As neurotics, we fear many things, but what we fear most is losing control. Fear drives us to take responsibility for everyone and everything—except ourselves. We create our own soap operas or watch the soap opera lives of others, distracting ourselves with drama rather than dealing with our fears. We really have very little vision for changing ourselves, which is why most religions and philosophies claim that no one really changes. That is not, however, the message of Christianity. Perhaps one of the most shocking assertions of the Bible is that you can change. By examining and tackling your neurosis, you can repent. You can turn around. You can go home.²

Jesus invites you to turn around and come home. He wants to help you find the person you were designed to be before the world, your culture, your upbringing, and your fear kidnapped you and carried you into a far country of anxiety and lost potential. The ransom has been paid for you, and if you are a Christian, you have a built-in guide—the Holy Spirit, who can lead you back to where you belong.

In First John we are taught that only God's love working through us can cast out fear.³ Fear reveals itself in so many ways. We can feel rage, disgust, grief, shame, hate, resentment, competition, or we might

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

² Luke 15:14–24.

³ 1 John 4:18.

become numb, but the underlying emotion is fear. Fear can be our friend, however. It is the flag that tells us that we are not accessing the love of God. That is a very helpful realization. Fear identifies the areas of our house that are built on sand, and once we have identified those areas, we can start rebuilding on the solid rock of God's love.

KF Facilitator Guide

Ch. 7: *General Measures to Relieve Tension*¹

0:00 Weekly/0:00 Weekend Intensive (WI)

Lead Facilitator starts the recording by pressing *9.

“Welcome everyone to the session 7 of the KF *Neurosis and Human Growth* book study. We will begin by reading the Introduction to this chapter.”

Support Facilitator reads the Introduction.

Lead Facilitator: “Thank you. Let’s go to Presenting. When you give us your name and location, you might also share what you do to relax. I will begin.”

“My name is _____. I am calling from _____ and to relax I like to _____.”

- Facilitators open the [NHG Spreadsheet](#) to record attendance and homework completion.
- Each facilitator makes a list of the names of students as they present.
- Lead facilitator prepares group divisions while students present.
- Lead facilitator assigns groups and says, “To leave the main group, press *3 and then, when prompted, enter your group number. To return to the main group, press *3*.”
- Each facilitator asks, “Is there anyone who has not filled out their reading guide?”
- Each facilitator assigns the first 10 questions to two students, 5 questions each. Continue to answer the questions in sets of 10, assigning 5 questions per student in rotation.

Questions 9, 11, and 19 are open to the whole group, and there are no correct answers.

0:20/0:10 WI

1. What is now the condition of the inner situation? (176.1)

It is replete with disruptive conflicts, unbearable tensions, and potential terrors.

2. What distinguishes the search for glory from normal healthy strivings? (176.1)

Its colossal egocentricity.

Neurotics are only interested in you as a means of supporting their pride. They lack real connection or empathy and cannot really imagine how things might be for you. What you say or do evokes a personal reaction in them. They cannot think about you without thinking about themselves, and the role that they have created for themselves. This makes neurotics untrustworthy. If their search for glory is threatened, they will sacrifice those around them to restore their pride. They feel safer if they can compulsively fulfill their shoulds, demand accommodation for their claims, and run from self-hate. Fear is their primary motivator.

3. Alienation from self results in part from what? (177.3)

From active moves away from the real self and against the real self.

4. By disavowing the real self the neurotic is trying to avoid what? (177.3)

The neurotic is trying to avoid an inner battle and to keep inner tension at a minimum.

This is one of the reasons that students drop out of the book study. As the battle is consciously revealed, they feel a lot of tension. Since they have spent their lives avoiding that battle, their habit is to believe that the tension is bad and to escape the tension through whatever means possible is good. This work is scary, and sometimes we need to take a break from it and tackle the tension again at another time. KF offers these book studies every January.

5. If we suppress one aspect of any conflict and make the other predominant, what results? (177.3)

Any conflict within or without can vanish from sight and actually be (artificially) diminished.

Example: You can either choose hostility toward people or choose to accommodate others. If you choose hostility, then you don't have to worry about accommodating. If you choose to be accommodating, you don't have to worry about the risk of hostility if you stand up for yourself or push against opposition.

6. The withdrawing of the real self from the field of action is dictated by what need? (178.2)

The need for survival, the desire not to be torn apart.

Bless your idealized self for helping you to survive and for giving you a sense of integration in a difficult world. You can bless it and allow it to go. The former thing passes away, and all things are becoming new.

7. What must neurotics leading a double life unconsciously do? (178.3)

Blur the truth of what they are, want, feel, believe.

All of our self-deception follows from blurring this truth. As Christians, we also blur the truth about the quality of our faith, even when faced with the real evidence of our lives.

We must maintain our confusion about our real wants, feelings, and beliefs so that we can live more effortlessly through pride.

8. What does the externalization of inner experiences mean? (178.4)

Externalization means that the inner (intrapsychic) processes are not experienced as such but are perceived or felt as occurring between self and the outside world.

If we feel conflict with someone or with an institution or group, 90% of the time we are actually feeling the neurotic conflict that is going on within ourselves.

We can personalize things to an alarming degree. If the sink gets stopped up, we want to kill the sink for having assaulted the glory of an effortless life without limitations. We may now begin to recognize that when we personalize events or circumstances, our suffering may be the result of our self-hate.

We might make the judgment, "How insensitive or mean they are!" but actually what they have said only makes us feel rejected or hurt. In our egocentricity, we have a claim that others are there to make us feel good about ourselves. We cannot allow others to deal with their own conflicts if we are not dealing with our own. When faced with threat or anger, only our conflicts matter – others have inadvertently stepped on our landmines and we blame them for our explosions. Explosions look different for different types: withdrawing and avoiding; tears and blaming; unyielding aggression and rage.

9. Which of Dr. Horney's examples of externalization do you recognize in your own life? (179.1)

Open this question to the group. Examples from the book are in bold.

- Laying on other people's doorsteps all the blame for all one's own shortcomings or ailments
- Attributing to others the hostility we unconsciously feel toward ourselves
- Every inner process can be externalized (e.g., feeling compassion for others but finding it impossible to feel compassion for oneself)
- Spotting how others are stuck, but unable to spot our own inertia
- Rebelling against the coercion of inner dictates, which appears as defiance of conventions, laws, influences
- Unaware of our own overbearing pride, but hating it or being fascinated by it in others
- Smoothing over the ruthless cruelty of self-hate by adopting a Pollyanna-like attitude toward life in general
- Blaming and punishing others and making them the problem
- Demanding that others be perfect or do as they are told (reflecting how our real self is not submitting to our shoulds and claims!)
- Desire to help others grow when I won't make the effort to grow
- Whenever the Lord is inviting me to move on, I feel anxiety and use my environment or my job as an excuse to stay stuck
- Unaware of our own pride but hating it in others

10. What is another neurotic tendency? (179.2)

We experience ourselves in a piecemeal way as if we were the sum total of disconnected parts. This is known in psychiatric literature as compartmentalization or psychic fragmentation.

There is no feeling for ourselves as whole organisms in which every part is related to the whole and interacts with every other part. We are actively interested in maintaining this disconnection.

Nancy worked with a man who said that he didn't know how he felt. She told him to look at his hands. They were tightly clenched together with white knuckles. Nancy asked if he might be feeling some tension. He thought that maybe he was. He was experiencing himself as a mind that didn't know how he felt, but his body was screaming information at him. He was so compartmentalized that he could not make the connection.

We may be unable to connect a job with the money we earn or connect an affair with a broken marriage. We may feel rage in a relationship but disconnect the rage from the actual cause.

0:30/0:15 WI

11. Have you experienced any of these, or other, disconnections? (180.2–181.1)

Open this question to the group. Examples from the book are in bold.

- **We have an unconscious interest in not seeing cause and effect—in not recognizing that one psychic factor follows from another or reinforces another. We must maintain a certain attitude because it protects an important illusion.**
For example, I may be depressed because of my own resistance to growth, but my story is that I am depressed because life isn't going my way. I must disconnect from reality to maintain the claim that I have a god-like power to control my circumstances.
- **Unaware of contradictory values coexisting in us, e.g., a desire to be saintly and a desire to make others subservient to us.**

- **We refuse to face the underlying conflicts and thereby keep our inner tension at a low ebb, which helps us preserve the *status quo*.**
- **Clipping the link between cause and effect, disconnecting the two.**

We are unaware of or refuse to acknowledge the connection between cause and effect. We cannot recognize how our choices produce a certain outcome and how our behavior affects others.

We often cannot see how the quality of our lives or the lives of our children is the product of our choices.

We can impose artificial control systems that may seem spiritual, good, necessary, or logical (for example, following the dictates a parenting book or a book on building a functional marriage), but our real concern is about following the “rules”. We refuse to look at the outcomes that those rules are producing. “Obeying God”, “doing it right”, and “submission or authority laws” often demonstrates a lack of connection to cause and effect, especially when the outcome of those rules isn’t producing the Fruit of the Spirit or the attributes of love. With rules, we can imagine ourselves to be righteous and yet do nothing that is healthy. We are fragmented.

12. What do these three attempts at preserving a semblance of inner peace have in common? (181.2)

They have in common the character of doing away with elements which carry the potentials to disrupt the neurotic structure.

13. What is the main function of automatic control? (181.2)

The main function is to put a check on feelings.

Real feelings can be a source of danger to a system on the verge of disintegration because they are untamed elementary forces.

Real feelings can feel irrational and crazy. Our feelings react to everything without discrimination, like a smoke alarm that shrieks at us whether the toast or the house is burning. Small things can make us feel like the house is burning down. In KF training we learn to adjust the alarm to suit what the situation requires.

14. What is necessary to hold together the discrepant parts of a fragmented, alienated self? (181.3)

An artificial control system to hold together the discrepant parts of ourselves.

When we try to save our neurotic lives through automatic control, we end up losing our life.

As neurotics our lives are driven by a slave master who is only interested in achieving the goal already mapped out in his mind. There is no room for discovery and no appreciation of progress. Our alternative is to learn a healthy organic system of self-management that fosters congruence. Our lives can be shepherded toward an unforeseen potential that is increasingly discovered as we let go of neurosis.

15. When also may neurotics become panicky? (182.3)

When we realize that our control system is not functioning.

When our carefully controlled circumstances and relationships are exposed to reality, we sense that our lives are unravelling, and we have no tools for handling the unexpected or painful.

Small or large shocks send us into unhealthy and sometimes crazy behaviors that are fear-driven, like the panicking boss in the movie *The Incredibles* who becomes aware that people are “penetrating the bureaucracy!” He thinks that penetration is the most threatening problem he has. Actually, what is really terrifying him is that his control system has ceased to function.

0:35/0:25 WI

16. What is the last general measure the author describes? (182.4)

The neurotic’s belief in the supremacy of the mind.

It’s very difficult for the neurotic to endure the tension of “not knowing”. In KF we train to be able to maintain our peace when we are confronted with events that we can’t figure out or understand. We understand that these events are training opportunities, and through our training we know that we are equipped to manage them.

Examples of our belief in the supremacy of the mind:

- “I can always talk myself or others into believing I am right.”
- “If I can get it straight in my mind, then I will feel safe.”
- “I can only follow the guidance about my problem if I fully understand the solution offered.”

When we consider our lives in terms of “if only” (e.g., if only we were smarter, richer, better-looking), we are actually trying to support our pride system. One man said, “If only I looked like Brad Pitt, I would be a successful businessman.” In his mind he had his failures figured out. He didn’t want to accept that before he could be successful, he had to deal with his pride. He wanted to avoid the hard work of learning, so he shifted the responsibility for his failures to his appearance.

17. The neurotic mind opposes what aspects of ourselves? (183.1)

- A. **Feelings** – we judge our feelings as good or bad, repressing or indulging them rather than observing and understanding them.
- B. **Body** – we minimize our status as creatures. We don’t want to deal with living in a physical body that has needs and limitations.
- C. **Self** – we suppress anything that does not complement our idealized self. People often say that they do not know who they are, but they are actively suppressing the recognition of themselves.

18. In what three ways does the neurotic’s belief in the supremacy of the mind serve to release tension, cover up conflicts, and establish a sense of unity? (182.4–185.1)

- A. **The mind can become a spectator of self** – detached, like watching a character in a play; judging, faultfinding, etc., and assuming that others are watching us as we are watching ourselves.
- B. **The mind works as a coordinator** – fanatic logic, unshakeable belief in one’s own infallibility: “My logic is the only logic.” Coordinators may suffer under pervasive self-doubt but will gladly tell others how things are. They claim to have God’s attribute of omniscience (all knowing) and believe that “My ways are higher than your ways and my thoughts are higher than your thoughts.” (Isaiah 55:8-9)
- C. **The mind is the magic ruler for which, as for God, everything is possible** – knowing is no longer a step toward changing, but knowing *is* changing. When nothing changes, the neurotic is bewildered and the endless search for more knowledge continues.

We are not taught in our culture to look at the evidence of our lives and learn tools to change our lives. We are taught to go to school, get a degree, go to church or a Bible study, get some counseling, read another book, have enough faith, look for another “get rich quick” scheme, pray more, and hope that the unconscious factors that are creating our problems will then just go away. We might even work hard to understand the unconscious factors at work but refuse to do the difficult work of changing our lives. Just knowing more or following a system more closely will not magically make our inner conflicts go away. Joining KF without making an effort to do the work will not relieve our chronic inner tension. When we work to deal with this tension, we will be able to live consistently productive and healthy lives.

19. Which of the above three methods of relieving tension, covering up conflicts and establishing a semblance of unity do you use most often? (182.4–185.1)

Open this question to the group.

You might refer to the notes for Question 18 and start by discussing Option A, the “spectator of self”. Ask if anyone in the group identifies with that choice for establishing a sense of unity. Then move to the other two choices.

0:40/0:30 WI

20. What is less tolerable the more we try to manage life with pure intellect? (185.2)

It is less tolerable to acknowledge the existence of unconscious factors in us.

Some students have admitted that they are terrified of the unconscious factors working within them. We have not been trained to question ourselves or to correlate our inner life with our external outcomes. We can feel panic when we become aware that there are unconscious factors in charge. We may experience this terror in our dreams because in dreams we cannot manage the events of the dream with pure intellect.

21. What becomes ineffectual when we choose to just “get by” and re-establish a semblance of inner “peace”? (185.2)

All the good work we put in to bring a conflict into clear relief becomes ineffectual.

The desire to re-establish a semblance of inner peace is a very compelling emotion, and we will sacrifice anything, even all of our good work, in our desperation to feel at peace with and within ourselves.

22. In what ways do neurotic solutions become a way of life? (186.1)

- **They give form and direction to the whole personality**
- **They determine the kinds of satisfactions which are attainable, the factors to be avoided, the hierarchy of values, the relation to others**
- **They determine the kind of general integrating measures employed**

Nancy would add: They give us a framework that enables us to deal with life in automatic or preprogrammed ways.

Because these neurotic solutions give our lives a form of stability and structure, we find it very difficult to change them. We will not be able to give up our neurotic solutions until we have a stronger foundation. Developing that foundation is the work of KF training. One member said that they were unaware that they didn’t have peace until they began to experience real peace. They can now

look back on their life and see how chronic tension was driving them. Most of us are content with simply calming inner tension, but real peace is something very different and very powerful.

Accommodating tension will not produce peace. Real peace grows as your real self grows.

If time permits, the facilitator might read the following:

Although alienation from ourselves creates debilitating tension, Psalm 139 assures us that wherever we go and in whatever situation we find ourselves the Lord is with us. You might read through this psalm in the light of what you are learning in this study. God knows you. He knows who you are and what you can do. He is longing to lead you back to yourself. Our KF prayer comes from this psalm.

Search me, O God, and reveal my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain (harm or damage) and lead me in the ways of eternity.
(Psalm 139:23–24)

0:45/0:45 WI

All students take a five-minute break. Break-out room (subgroup) facilitator returns to the main meeting (*3*) to report attendance and homework, then goes back to the subgroup and waits for the next facilitator to arrive before signing off. Facilitator, do not turn off the recording.

Facilitators: “Are there any further comments or questions about this chapter?”

All facilitators: during the break, please record student attendance and homework completion on the [NHG Attendance Spreadsheet](#) located on the website under NHG Facilitator Info tab.

¹ This reading guide refers to the 1991 edition of *Neurosis and Human Growth: The Struggle Toward Self-Realization* by Karen Horney, published by W.W. Norton and Company Inc. New York.